time, though, the threat of catastrophe is internal: a political confrontation that could lead to civil war—unimaginable, and yet this is not pure fiction. One cannot believe that this is not pure fiction.

The only event I remember as something slightly similar happened in June 1948, when "my" ship, the *Altalena*, a "liberty ship" of World War II vintage, docked off the shores of Kfar Vitkin with its 900 passengers (most would-be soldiers, but also some real soldiers, Americans and others). It carried tons of weapons and ammunition. The ship had been chartered by American Revisionists (led by Peter Bergson) and those who gave it the order to sail were French Revisionists, in both cases political allies of Menachem Begin, the chief of the Irgun in Palestine, a terrorist right-wing underground movement during the British Mandate, that was fiercely fought against by the mandatory power and by the mainstream left-wing parties of the Jewish community, mainly Ben-Gurion's Mapai ("the workers party of Eretz Israel"). The names have changed between then and now but, basically, the opposite camps are not entirely dissimilar, unfortunately with reversed roles.

Notwithstanding his impassioned calls for support, Begin did not have a chance against Zahal (the Israeli defense forces). The *Altalena* sailed to the shore at Tel Aviv, as Begin hoped to raise the city's population to its defense. To no avail. The ship was set on fire by what Ben-Gurion called "the blessed gun." Sixteen men were killed, some while swimming ashore. The blackened hull remained in full view from the coast for several months, before being sold for scrap.

Saturday, February 18

I read in the news that several veterans of the fighting on the Golan during the Yom Kippur War were about to transport an armored car, sent there in commemoration, to the coming demonstration in Tel Aviv; the police